



△ Ruby ring from the parure in its current form

Danish ruby parure

The Danish ruby parure is a breathtakingly beautiful set of jewellery, with a royal pedigree that stretches back over 200 years. Its story begins with the coronation of Napoleon I in 1804. To ensure that this was a spectacular occasion, he gave all his marshals funds to buy new jewellery for their ladies. Among them was Jean Bernadotte, who commissioned the parure for his wife, Désirée Clary. Both were commoners at this point, but Bernadotte was later elected heir to the Swedish throne, and Désirée became Queen Desideria (see pp.108–09). The parure passed into the Danish royal family in 1869, when Princess Louise received the jewels as a wedding present. Although Swedish herself, she was marrying the future King Frederik VIII of Denmark. The gift was deemed particularly appropriate as the diamonds and rubies echoed the colours of the Danish flag. The parure currently belongs to Crown Princess Mary of Denmark.

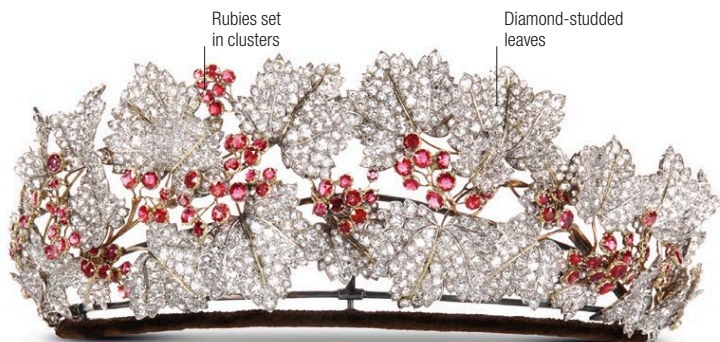
The showpiece of the parure is the stunning wreath tiara, composed of diamond-encrusted leaves and ruby “berries”. The small rubies have been cleverly set in clusters, so that they appear



Napoleon I crowns his wife Josephine as empress in a painting by Jacques-Louis David, 1807

larger. Their colouring is light, nearer to pink than blood-red, but it has been claimed that this makes them more wearable, especially with blue or purple ensembles.

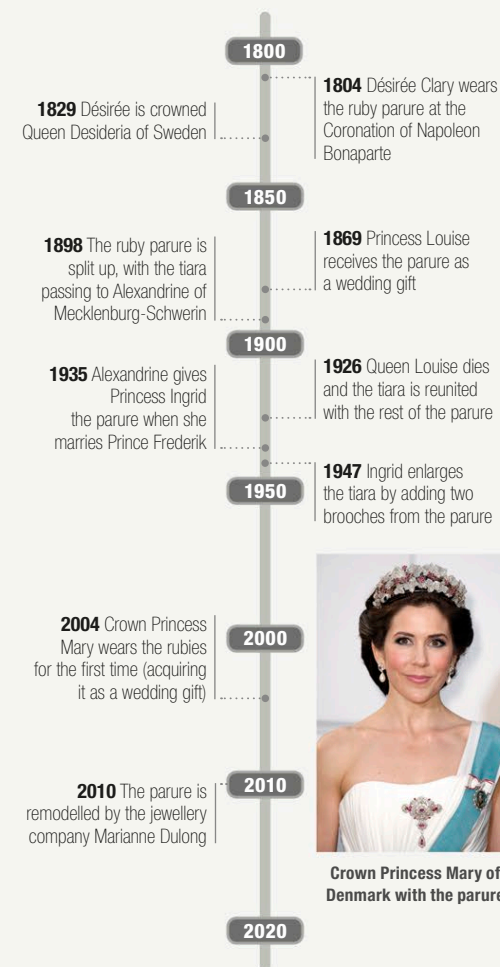
The precise make-up of the parure has varied over the years. Originally, the leaves were hair ornaments, and they were only modelled into a tiara in 1898. There have since been two major restylings, in 1947 and 2010. In these, the tiara has been made more compact, while the girandole earrings and necklace have been modified, to allow them to be worn with different accessories.



Tiara from the parure featuring leaf shapes set with diamonds, interspersed with “berry” clusters composed of rubies

Key dates

1804–2010



I see the natural beauty of the stones... I look at colours, sharpening, brightness

Per **Dirksen**

Goldsmith, on the remodelling of the tiara